

Semantics: Word Meanings

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1. Find a pair of absolute synonyms in a language that you speak.
2. Decide if the words in the following sets are absolute or near synonyms. How do you decide? What type of criteria have you used?

(1) *tell, say, talk*

(2) *sad, unhappy*

3. Classify the following pairs of opposites

(3) *temporary/permanent* (8) *advance/retreat*

(4) *red/green* (9) *buyer/seller*

(5) *strong/weak* (10) *clean/dirty*

(6) *open/shut* (11) *present/absent*

(7) *monarch/subject* (12) *yesterday/today*

4. Classify the following related words

(13) *begin/start* (19) *palette/painting*

(14) *class/education* (20) *segment/orange*

(15) *slice/pie* (21) *scalpel/surgery*

(16) *sand/grain* (22) *vehicle/bicycle*

(17) *tree/forest* (23) *smart/intelligent*

(18) *bee/swarm*

5. Below are some nouns ending in *-er* and *-or*. Using your intuition about their meanings, discuss their status as agentive nouns. In particular, are they derivable by regular rule or would they need to be listed in the lexicon?

*teacher, author, blazer, blinker, choker, loser, debtor,
loner, mentor, reactor, roller, lecturer*

Check your decisions against a dictionary's entries.

6. Give examples of agentive suffixes in other languages you speak

Acknowledgments Some of these questions are partially based on exercises from Saeed (2003, ch3)